

BEFORE

Some historians have linked Celtic origins with the **Urnfield culture** (so named because urns containing the ashes of the dead were placed in fields), which dates from around 1200 BCE and was based in France and Germany. It is also thought that Celtic ancestry may be rooted in the Eurasian steppes.

HALLSTATT CULTURE

Archaeological finds place the first Celts in **Hallstatt** (Austria) in around 700 BCE—the early Iron Age. The Hallstatt Celts seem to have been one of Europe's **first Iron Age cultures** and appear to have been wealthy and powerful. Their chieftains' graves contained valuable items such as bronze buckets and jewelry, suggesting trade with Greece and domination of several major European trading routes.



HALLSTATT
BRONZE WAGON

CELTIC ADVANCE

By around 500 BCE, the Celts had settled in pockets of France, Germany, and what is now the western part of the Czech Republic. About 100 years later, a significant spread of Celtic tribes into many parts of Europe began, notably into northern Italy. They settled in the Po valley before sacking Rome (c. 390 BCE). The extent of the Celtic "invasion" is a matter of debate.

CELTIC QUEEN (DIED 60 CE)

BOUDICCA

Queen of the Celtic Iceni people of eastern England, Boudicca (or Boadicea) led a bloody uprising against occupying Roman forces after the Romans ignored the will of her dead husband, King Prasutagus. The king had left his estate jointly to his daughters and to Rome, but Romans seized his entire kingdom and mistreated his family. Boudicca sacked Colchester and Londinium but was finally defeated, and is thought to have killed herself to avoid capture.



The word "Celt" refers to many groups of Europeans who spoke related Indo-European languages and migrated across Europe from the 5th century BCE. They are sometimes called "the first masters of Europe." Although the Celts were not one cohesive people, and were composed of numerous and fairly diverse groups, they displayed a common culture. This culture was typified by organization into tribes or clans, a nomadic or village life existence, and a strong warrior tradition.



The Dying Gaul

This copy of a Greek statue commemorates a Greek victory against invading "Gauls" (Celts) in the 220s BCE. The torc around the Gaul's neck is a sign of Celtic identity.

part of Celtic culture. Stories would also have been about Celtic beliefs and deities. Celtic mythology featured a strong belief in an afterlife—an "otherworld" realm less like a heaven and more of a parallel with the real world, much like the ancient Egyptian

afterlife (see pp.68–69). The Celtic otherworld was peopled by gods and supernatural beings, such as Cernunnos, horned god of virility, nature, and plenty. The Celts believed that people journeyed to the otherworld after death, and great feasts were held as preparation for chiefs' burials. Woodland spirits were believed to inhabit the otherworld, and

Celtic Warriors

Fierce warriors and skilled ironworkers with a love of feasting, the Celts swept across much of Europe during the 1st millennium BCE. Their advance brought them in contact with many of the cultures that shaped history, including the Greeks and Romans. Later, they played a part in the rise of Christianity.

By the 200s BCE, Celts and their culture were prevalent across a large swath of Western and Central Europe. In the 4th century BCE, they had already sacked (plundered) Rome. The next few centuries saw them reach the British Isles and move across Italy, France, Spain, Greece, Macedonia, and modern Turkey, sending delegations to Alexander the Great (see pp.96–97) in the 300s BCE and sacking Delphi, Greece, in 279 BCE. They met with varying fortunes, sometimes victorious and sometimes defeated. Where they did triumph, there was a significant exchange of cultures between the Celts and those they had conquered.

Tribal structure

Celtic society was an agricultural one of fortified villages, and was organized into many inter-fighting tribes or clans. The tribe was more important than the individual. Tribal structure was hierarchical, with a king or chief at the head; followed by noble-warriors and priests (druids); commoners, many of whom were farmers; and slaves. Druids had a very special status in Celtic society. They came from leading families and were exempted from paying taxes or taking part in fighting. The different tribes had cultural, rather than political, common ground. This lack of political cohesion was ultimately a weakness (see AFTER).

Beliefs and mythology

The Celts were illiterate, even at their height, but had a powerful oral tradition of storytelling and poetry. Epic poems of war exploits and glories are an especially important



A godlike figure appears to dip a man into, or remove him from, a cauldron, perhaps as an "Otherworld" rebirth or initiation ritual.

Noble horsemen may be riding away after rebirth in the cauldron. Their helmets have symbolic decoration such as crescent shapes, boars, or birds.